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THA 213: Theatre History from the Renaissance to the 19th Century

How revolutions, technology and money rebuilt the stage

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

This pack links theatre change to political and industrial change: the Renaissance recovery of classical texts, the rise of commercial playhouses, the director, melodrama, minstrel shows and new stage technology. It also shows you how the history sequence was renumbered between the 2018 and 2019 departmental listings.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Trace major European theatre developments from the Renaissance to 1900.
- Explain how industrial and political change shaped theatre architecture and production.
- Connect the rise of the director to changes in staging and rehearsal.
- Interpret the archive entries showing how the department reorganised this course.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Renaissance to Enlightenment

Recovered classical texts changed what could be staged and how.

- Humanist scholarship revived Roman comedy and Senecan tragedy.
- Commedia dell'arte professionalised touring improvisation.
- Court masque and spectacle fused design, music and politics.
- Neoclassical rules constrained structure until Romantic practice broke them.
- Purpose-built playhouses created a paying public and a commercial profession.

- Printing made plays available as literature, not only as performance.

Revolution, industry and melodrama

The 19th century is the hinge between repertory theatre and modern production.

- Political revolution changed censorship, audiences and subject matter.
- Gas and later electric lighting enabled picture-stage realism and controlled mood.
- Railways created touring circuits and star actors with national reputations.
- Melodrama offered clear morality, spectacle and music to mass audiences.
- Minstrel shows spread racist caricature while shaping popular entertainment formats.
- Realism and naturalism responded with claims to scientific observation.

> **Technology is dramaturgy**
> Lighting, scene-shifting machinery and proscenium staging did not merely decorate plays; they changed what writers could write.

The rise of the director

Directing emerged as a profession when production became too complex for the actor-manager alone.

- Ensemble coherence replaced star-centred staging in key companies.
- Rehearsal became a structured period rather than a formality.
- Designers and directors coordinated unified visual concepts.
- Scripts were interpreted rather than simply recited.
- The director's authority also centralised power in production.
- This history explains why directing is a separate course in your programme.

Why stages changed when the world changed

Theatre history is easiest to remember as a chain of cause and effect between three things: who paid, what was believed, and what could be built. In the medieval period the church funded performance and belief organised the material, so plays were cycles staged on pageant wagons or in churchyards, moving through a town rather than sitting in a building.

The Renaissance rearranged all three. Courts and academies paid, humanist learning made classical texts desirable, and the invention of perspective painting supplied a technique for representing distance. Once you can paint a street receding to a vanishing point, you can build a set that imitates it, and once you do that, the audience must sit in one place to see it correctly. The proscenium arch is the architectural result of a way of seeing.

This is the single most useful idea for exam answers on this period: the picture-frame stage is not a neutral container. It decides where the audience sits, what they can see, and what kind of illusion the production is trying to produce.